2. SOC Analyst vs VAPT / Penetration Tester vs Incident Responder

All three work in security, but they look at it from different angles. The SOC analyst watches, the pen tester attacks (with permission), and the incident responder cleans up when something has already gone wrong.

	SOC Analyst	VAPT / Penetration Tester	Incident Responder
Goal	Detect and triage threats as early as possible	Find weaknesses before real attackers do	Contain, investigate and recover from a confirmed incident
Daily work	Monitoring alerts, checking logs, deciding if an alert is real or a false positive, escalating, writing tickets	Scanning, manual testing, exploiting issues in a controlled way, writing a report with fixes	Isolating infected machines, collecting evidence, finding root cause, removing the threat, writing the incident report
Tools	SIEM (Splunk, Wazuh, QRadar), EDR, Wireshark, threat intel feeds	Nmap, Burp Suite, Metasploit, Nikto, SQLmap, Kali Linux	Volatility, Autopsy, FTK Imager, EDR, SIEM, log analysis tools
Team	Blue team (defence)	Red team (offence)	Blue team (defence)
When they work	Continuously, often in shifts (24x7)	Project based, usually for a fixed period with a defined scope	On demand, when an incident is declared
Output	Alerts, tickets, escalations	Vulnerability report with risk ratings	Incident report, lessons learned, recovery

Key points

- SOC L1 is usually the entry point for freshers. The job is mostly triage: is this alert real?
- A pen tester needs written permission and a defined scope before touching anything.
- Incident responders overlap with digital forensics, since evidence handling matters in legal cases.
- Purple teaming is when red and blue teams work together to improve detection.